Portfolio Projects for BUSINESS COMMUNICATIONS

Chapter 4

Everyday Letters

NEW PERSPECTIVES



Objectives

- Identify letter types
- Structure everyday letters
- Format letters
- Determine when to use a form letter
- Identify the components of a form letter
- Use mail merge in Word

Introduction

- Everyday letters communicate neutral information for common business situations
  - Sent via e-mail or printed letter mailed in envelope
- Form letters are used to send the same or similar information to a large number of recipients
  - Personalized by adding recipient-specific information

Everyday Letters (cont'd.)

- Identifying letter type
  - Regardless of content, purpose is to generate goodwill
    - Positive feeling or impression that a company's reputation creates in the mind of a customer

Everyday Letters (cont'd.)

Letter Type	Purpose	Example
Request	To request items or services	A travel agency requests information about tours to Ireland from an Irish tour operator.
Confirmation	To confirm an agreement, a meeting, or an event	A speaker confirms with an event planner that he will deliver a presentation at an upcoming conference.
Transmittal	To accompany an attachment such as a report, a resume, promotional materials, or a shipped order	A consultant submits to the school board a report she was hired to write on playground safety.
Acceptance	To say yes to a reader's request	A human resources director informs a job applicant that he has been hired.
Personal	To say thank you or to offer congratulations or condolences; these letters are generally handwritten and personalized	A business associate congratulates a colleague on a promotion.

Figure 4-1 Everyday letter types

Everyday Letters (cont'd.)

- Structuring an everyday letter
  - All types of everyday letters share a similar format:
    - First paragraph includes reason for the letter and usually a reference to the reader
    - Second paragraph provides additional details
    - Last paragraph thanks the reader and invites action and/or further contact

Request Letter

- Developing request letters
  - Written to ask for something
    - Many are sent via e-mail

Request Letter

Paragraph	Purpose	Example
Paragraph 1	State the request	Option 1: No previous contact I am writing to request information about your tours of Ireland. I am working with a corporate client who wishes to provide a trip to Ireland for 10 employees and their guests. The trip is scheduled for the last three weeks in June of this year. Option 2: Previous contact Thank you for speaking with me on March 2 about your tours of Ireland. As I indicated in that conversation, I require information to plan a trip to Ireland on behalf of my corporate client. The trip is scheduled for the last three weeks in June of this year.
Paragraph 2	Provide additional details (use a bulleted list if appropriate)	Please provide me with the following information: • Suggested itinerary for a three-week tour that includes Dublin, Belfast, Cork, and a one-week stay in a cottage in the west of Ireland • Suggested hotels; the budget is €150 per night • Suggested cottage rentals in the west of Ireland • Suggested activities suitable for active couples • Transportation options • Estimated cost of the trip
Paragraph 3	Close positively and invite further contact	Please call me at (505) 555-1770 if you have any questions about my request. Thank you for your quick attention to this request. I look forward to hearing from you soon.

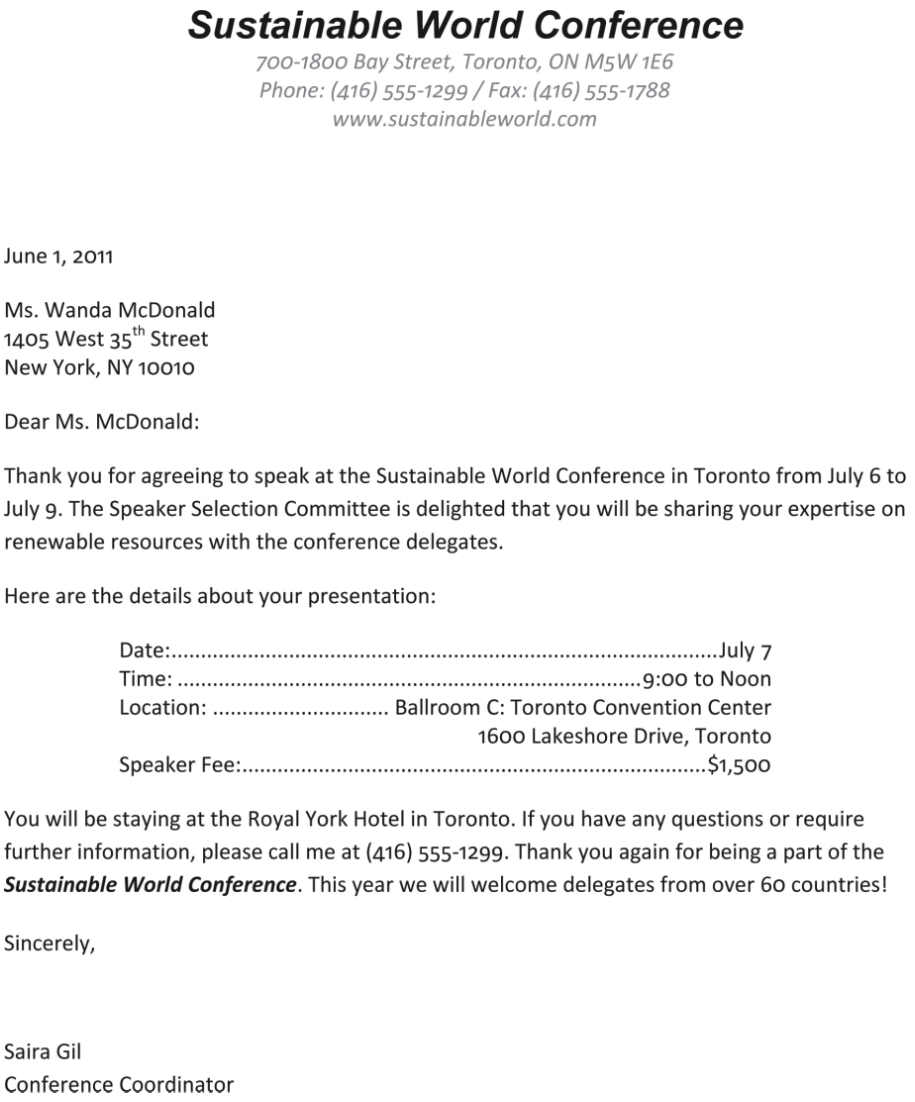
Figure 4-2 Request letter structure

Confirmation Letter

- Developing confirmation letters
  - Written to confirm a formal agreement

Confirmation Letter

Figure 4-3 Sample confirmation letter



Sustainable World Conference

700-1800 Bay Street, Toronto, ON M5W 1E6
Phone: (416) 555-1299 / Fax: (416) 555-1788
www.sustainableworld.com

June 1, 2011

Ms. Wanda McDonald
1405 West 35th Street
New York, NY 10010

Dear Ms. McDonald:

Thank you for agreeing to speak at the Sustainable World Conference in Toronto from July 6 to July 9. The Speaker Selection Committee is delighted that you will be sharing your expertise on renewable resources with the conference delegates.

Here are the details about your presentation:

Date:.....July 7
Time: .....9:00 to Noon
Location: ..... Ballroom C: Toronto Convention Center
1600 Lakeshore Drive, Toronto
Speaker Fee:.....$1,500

You will be staying at the Royal York Hotel in Toronto. If you have any questions or require further information, please call me at (416) 555-1299. Thank you again for being a part of the ***Sustainable World Conference***. This year we will welcome delegates from over 60 countries!

Sincerely,

Saira Gil
Conference Coordinator

Transmittal Letter

- Developing transmittal letters (i.e., cover letters)
  - Accompanies attachment
  - Provides information about enclosure
  - May include a brief summary and description of expected action
  - Well-formatted transmittal letters signal importance

Transmittal Letter

Paragraph	Purpose	Example
Paragraph 1	State why you are writing, thank the reader if appropriate, and specify the attachment	Thank you for providing me with the opportunity to submit the enclosed proposal titled *Maple Road Traffic Safety Solutions*. The purpose of the proposal is to request that the municipality install a stop sign at the intersection of Maple Road and 1st Street in Baltimore.
Paragraph 2	Provide additional information about the attachment	As discussed in the proposal, 40 traffic accidents have occurred at the intersection of Maple Road and 1st Street since 1990. Data concerning these accidents, along with traffic patterns at different times of the day over a six-month period, is included in the proposal. A stop sign would help prevent more accidents by reducing traffic speed and volume because those motorists who do not want to stop will find an alternate route. Installation of a stop sign will also contribute significantly to the safety of pedestrians in the neighborhood.
Paragraph 3	Close positively and invite further contact	Please call me at (410) 555-1770 if you have any questions about the attached proposal or if you need any additional information. Thank you for your immediate attention to this matter. I look forward to hearing from you.

Figure 4-4 Transmittal letter structure

Acceptance Letter

- Developing acceptance letters
  - Written to respond positively to a request
  - Gives good news right away, provide details if required, and close positively

Acceptance Letter

Georgia Trails
896 Bent Tree Road, Athens, GA 30634
Phone: (706) 555-2233
www.georgiatrails.com



May 8, 2011

Mr. Robert Watson
340 Market Square
Cartersville, GA 30133

Dear Robert:

Thank you for applying for the position of recreation coordinator with Georgia Trails. Your qualifications, experience, and enthusiastic attitude impressed the hiring committee. We are delighted to offer you the position.

If you choose to accept this offer, we would like you to start working on June 1 in our Athens office. You will be working with five Trail Supervisors. As we discussed in the interview, your starting salary is $53,300 annually, including medical benefits.

Please call me at (706) 555-2233 to discuss your decision. Thank you, Robert, for applying to Georgia Trails. I look forward to welcoming you in June.

Sincerely,

Jonson Quade
Personnel Director

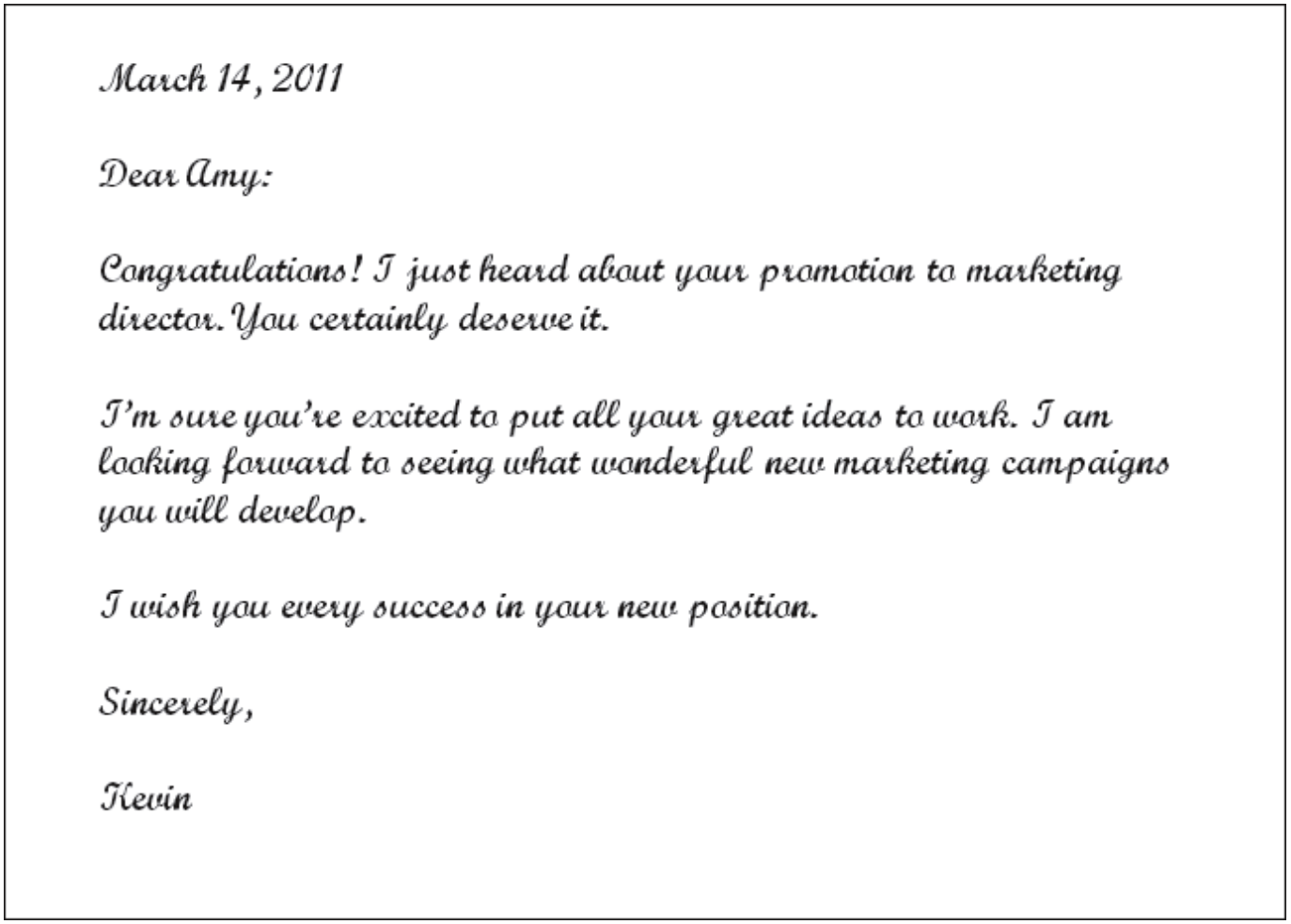
JQ/yn

Figure 4-5 Correctly structured acceptance letter

Personal Letters

- Developing personal letters
  - Includes thank you letters, letters of congratulations, and letters offering condolences
    - Thank you letters are written to show appreciation
    - Letters of congratulations are written to people that are promoted
    - Letters of condolence are the hardest, but one of the most important
  - Usually hand written
    - Thank you letters may be a form letter

Personal Letter



March 14, 2011

Dear Amy:

Congratulations! I just heard about your promotion to marketing director. You certainly deserve it.

I'm sure you're excited to put all your great ideas to work. I am looking forward to seeing what wonderful new marketing campaigns you will develop.

I wish you every success in your new position.

Sincerely,

Kevin

Figure 4-6 Sample letter of congratulations

Formatting Letters

- Formatting letters
  - Include an attractive letterhead
  - Select a business letter format (e.g., block or modified block)
  - Apply punctuation style for the salutation and complimentary closing

Formatting Letters

Letter Element	Description
Letterhead	• Include the following components: • Company name • Logo or company slogan, if available • Company street address • Company phone and fax numbers • Company e-mail address or Web site address • Limit the total height of the letterhead to no more than 1 to 2 inches.
Letter format	• When using the **block** letter format, start all lines at the left margin. • When using the **modified block** letter format, indent the date and closing lines to the center of the page and indent the first line of each paragraph five spaces.
Punctuation style	• Follow the salutation with a colon and the complimentary closing with a comma.

Figure 4-7 Letter formatting requirements

Fully-blocked style

- All parts begin at the left margin
- Just one clear line space between each section.

Open punctuation

- Only punctuate the essentials to ensure grammatical sense.
- Otherwise … no commas or full stops!

PARTS OF A BUSINESS LETTER

3.Date

- UK – day / month / year
- No commas 18 August 2007

- US - month / day / year
- August 18, 2000 (with comma)

4.Inside address

- Depending on culture
- Malaysia (postcode then city)
- UK/Singapore (postcode last row)

6. Salutation

- Mr / Ms / Mrs / Miss / Madam ?
- Dear _____
- Culture – Malay / Japanese / French
- Dear Sir / Madam (if name unknown)
- Dear Sirs (directed to a company / board of directors)

7. Heading

- Gives brief indication of content of letter.
- Specific
- Positive in tone
- Cases :
  - UPPERCASE
  - lowercase
  - Sentence case
  - Title Case
- Usually UPPERCASE
- May BOLD it

9. Complimentary close

Dear (NAME)

- Yours sincerely

Dear Sir / Madam / Sirs

- Yours faithfully

10. Signature section

- Leave 3-4 lines for a signature
- No underlining!
- Show name of sender and designation underneath it.

Yours faithfully

DOUG ALLEN
Financial Controller

Yours faithfully

Chloe Williamson (Ms)
Training Manager

Signing on someone's behalf

Yours sincerely

for JAKE BRADLEY

Chief Executive Officer

Yours sincerely

pp JAKE BRADLEY

Chief Executive Officer

pp – per procurationem

11. Enclosures

- At the foot of letter
- Enc (if there is only one attachment)
- Encs 2 (if more than 1, write the number too)

12. Copies / cc

- Carbon copy/Circulated copy/ Courtesy copy
- West – alphabetical order
- Malaysia – following ranks

e.g. Copies Monica Gupta, Publicity Manager
Ang Pei Soo, Co-ordinator

Formatting Letters

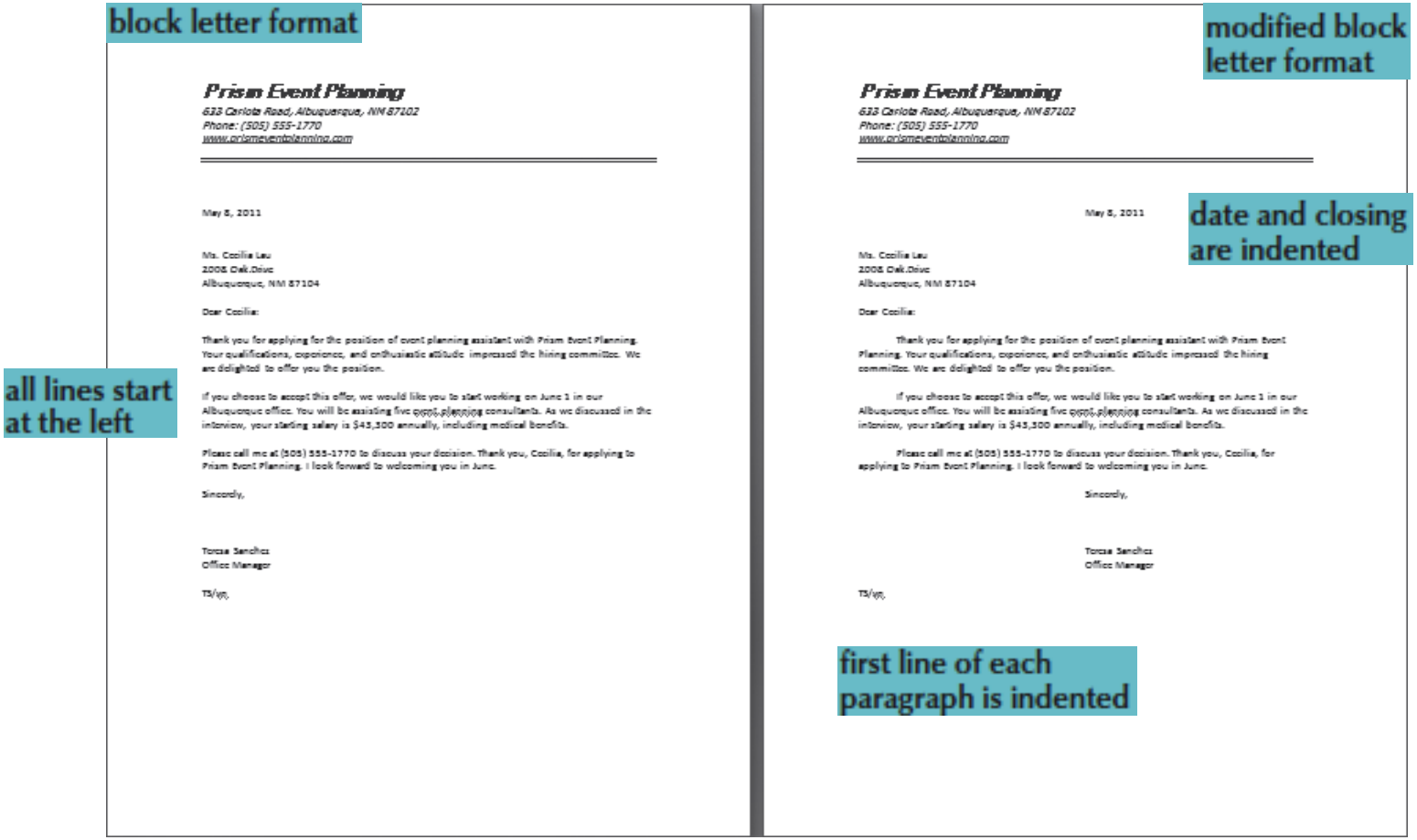


Figure 4-8 Letter formats

Everyday Letters (cont'd.)

- Determining when to use a form letter
  - Businesses use e-mail most frequently to communicate with clients
  - When a company needs to communicate information common to a great number of clients, they send a form letter
    - Contains basic message and customized information

Everyday Letters (cont'd.)

- Identifying components of a form letter
  - Two components:
    - Main document contains all common information required for every letter and merge fields for variable information
    - Data source contains variable information and fields (e.g., FIRST NAME and LAST NAME)
    - Record in a data source is a collection of variable information for one person
    - After you create main document and data source, insert merge fields

Everyday Letters (cont'd.)

- Creating the main document
  - Variable information is information that will be different in each printed form letter
  - You usually write a draft of a form letter
    - Includes placeholders to indicate where variable information goes

Everyday Letters (cont'd.)

- Creating the data source
  - Contains variable information for each person who will receive the form letter
    - Usually use a database
    - Create a flexible data source
  - Setting up four name fields allows you to personalize how the name appears in the letter
    - TITLE, FIRST NAME, LAST NAME, SALUTATION

Everyday Letters (cont'd.)

- Inserting merge fields and running the merge
  - After data source is created, replace placeholders in main document with merge fields from data source
    - In Word, highlight placeholder and use Insert Merge Field command
    - Run merge and view merged letters

Technology Skills
Merging Letters in Word

- Mail Merge function in Word:
  - Produces personalized form letters
  - Each letter contains the basic message you want all recipients to receive, along with variable information

Merging Letters in Word (cont'd.)

To initiate a mail merge:

1. Open the file **Tech_04.docx** located in the Project.04 folder included with your Data Files and then, to avoid altering the original file, save the document as **Transmittal Form Letter** in the same folder.
2. Read the letter and note where placeholders, such as [INSIDE ADDRESS], have been inserted in the form letter. The placeholders will be replaced with the merge fields that contain the variable information.
3. Click the **Mailings** tab, click the **Start Mail Merge** button in the Start Mail Merge group, and then click **Step by Step Mail Merge Wizard**. The Mail Merge task pane opens at Step 1 of 6.
4. Verify that Letters is selected as the document type, and then click **Next: Starting document**.
5. Verify that Use the current document is selected as the starting document, and then click **Next: Select recipients**. In the Mail Merge Wizard, the main document is referred to as the starting document.

Merging Letters in Word (cont'd.)

- Data source can be created from scratch or use an existing and adjust
  - When you create a data source from scratch, you work in the New Address List dialog box (contains common fields)
  - Next, customize a data source

Merging Letters in Word (cont'd.)

To customize a data source:

1. Click the **Type a new list** option button in the Select recipients area, and then click **Create** in the Type a new list area. The New Address List dialog box opens.
2. Click **Customize Columns** to open the Customize Address List dialog box, click **Home Phone** in the list of fields, click **Delete**, click **Yes**, and then delete the **Work Phone** and **E-Mail Address** fields.
3. Click **Add**, type **Event**, and then click **OK**. You can add as many new mail merge fields as you want.
4. Click **Add**, type **EventDate**, click **OK**, and then add **Invoice**, **Message**, and **Salutation**. You create a field for Salutation so that you can customize how you want to enter the greeting line. For some recipients, you may wish to write *Dear Mr. Adams,* while for other recipients, you may wish to write *Dear Lisa*.
5. With **Salutation** still selected, click **Move Up** until Salutation follows the Last Name field, and then click **OK**. You return to the New Address List dialog box. In this dialog box, you enter information about each recipient of your form letter.

Merging Letters in Word (cont'd.)

- Next, enter data for each person who will receive the form letter
  - You can leave a field blank
  - Next, enter data in the data source file

Merging Letters in Word (cont'd.)

To enter information into a data source:

1. Type **Mr.**, and then press the **Tab** key to move to the First Name field.
2. Enter the remaining information for George Adams, as shown in Figure 4-9.

Title	Mr.
First Name	George
Last Name	Adams
Salutation	Mr. Adams
Company	Gold Mark Enterprises
Address 1	1700 Palace Road
Address 2	Suite 300
City	Santa Fe
State	NM
ZIP Code	87112
Country	[Leave Blank]
Event	the launch of Paints on Parade, your new line of household paints
EventDate	May 3
Invoice	$9400
Message	During the event, you mentioned your interest in working with us again to sponsor a charitable event. I think your idea of featuring the new Paints on Parade would work very well. I will contact you in a few weeks to discuss plans.

Figure 4-9 Information for record 1

Merging Letters in Word (cont'd.)

3. Click **New Entry**, and then enter the information for record 2, as shown in Figure 4-10.

Title	Ms.
First Name	Lisa
Last Name	DeMarco
Salutation	Lisa
Company	[Leave Blank]
Address1	1200 Alameda Road
Address2	[Leave Blank]
City	Albuquerque
State	NM
ZIP Code	87102
Country	[Leave Blank]
Event	the wedding of your daughter Roquela
EventDate	May 15
Invoice	$15,800
Message	Your daughter looked stunning on her special day! I am so glad Roquela and Harrison enjoyed the wedding of their dreams. I am sure you must be very proud.

Figure 4-10 Information for record 2

4. Click **OK**, navigate to the location where you are storing files for this book, type **Transmittal Form Letter Data Source**, click **Save**, and then click **OK**.

Merging Letters in Word (cont'd.)

- When you create a new form letter, enter just a few records and then test the merge
  - Add and remove fields
  - Change common information
  - Adjust punctuation and spelling
- Replace placeholders in main document with merge fields from data source

Merging Letters in Word (cont'd.)

To add mail merge fields to a main document:

1. Click **Next: Write your letter**, select the **[INSIDE ADDRESS]** placeholder, press the **Delete** key, click **Address block** in the Mail Merge task pane, click **OK** to accept the default settings, and then press the **Enter** key once, if necessary, to add one blank line between the inside address and salutation.
2. Select the **[SALUTATION]** placeholder, press the **Delete** key, and then click the **Insert Merge Field** list arrow in the Write & Insert Fields group to display the list of fields.
3. Click **Salutation**, and then type a **colon** (:).
4. Follow the process described in steps 2 and 3 to insert the corresponding merge fields for the placeholders [**Event**], [**EventDate**], [**Invoice**], and [**Message**] in the appropriate places in the letter, as shown in Figure 4-11.

Figure 4-11 Mail merge fields inserted in the main document

Merging Letters in Word (cont'd.)

«AddressBlock»¶
¶
Dear·«Salutation»:¶
¶
Thank·you·for·choosing·Prism·Event·Planning·to·organize·the·«Event»·on·«EventDate».·I·am·delighted·that·you·and·your·guests·enjoyed·the·event·so·much.·Attached·is·our·invoice·for·«Invoice».·Our·terms·are·net·30·days.¶
¶
«Message»¶
¶
If·you·have·any·questions·about·the·attached·invoice,·please·call·me·at·(505)·555-1770.·Thank·you·again·for·choosing·Prism·Event·Planning·to·help·make·your·special·event·a·success.¶

be sure to insert a colon after the <<Salutation>> field

leave a space before and after the Event field

make sure a blank line appears after the Message merge field

keep the period following EventDate and Invoice

5. Type your name where indicated in the closing, and then save the document.

Figure 4-11 Mail merge fields inserted in the main document (cont'd.)

Merging Letters in Word (cont'd.)

- Preview each letter to make sure variable information is correct
  - Often you will need to make changes (e.g., common information, punctuation, spacing)
- Next, preview merged letter and make corrections to main document

Merging Letters in Word (cont'd.)

To preview a merged letter and correct errors:

1. Click **Next: Preview your letters**, and then read the first paragraph of the letter for George Adams. The first sentence does not sound right now that the variable information is entered. The sentence *Thank you for choosing Prism Event Planning to organize the the launch of Paints on Parade, your new line of household paints on May 3.* contains two errors. The word *the* appears twice and a comma is needed after *paints* because that is the end of the clause *your new line of household paints.*
2. Read the second paragraph. A noun is needed at the end of the phrase *the new Paints on Parade*. For example, the phrase should be *the new Paints on Parade product line.*
3. Click the **Next Record** button >> in the Mail Merge task pane to see the letter for Lisa DeMarco, and then read the letter for Lisa to find errors. Again the word *the* is repeated in the first sentence. Fortunately, the rest of the letter is fine.
4. Click **Previous: Write your letter** at the bottom of the Mail Merge task pane to move to Step 4, select **the** before <<Event>> in the first line of the first paragraph, and then press the **Delete** key.

Merging Letters in Word (cont'd.)

5. Click **Previous: Select recipients** to move to Step 3, click **Edit recipient list**, click **Transmittal Form Letter Data Source** in the Data Source area of the Mail Merge Recipients dialog box, and then click **Edit**. The Edit Data Source dialog box opens.
6. Press the **Tab** key to scroll to the entry under **Event** for George Adams, and then type a comma (,).
7. Tab to **Message**, use the arrow keys to move to the sentence that begins *I think your idea,* and then delete the sentence **I think your idea of featuring the new Paints on Parade will work very well.**
8. Click **OK**, click **Yes**, click **OK**, click **Next: Write your letter**, click **Next: Preview your letters**, and then click **Next: Complete the merge**.
9. Click **Edit individual letters**, click **OK** to merge all records into a new document, print a copy of both letters, save the document as **Transmittal Form Letter Merged**, and then close the document.
10. Click the **Preview Results** button in the Preview Results group on the Mailings tab to deselect it, and then save and close the main document. If you want to print individual letters, you can run the merge again.